

FREE SAMPLE

Axolotl Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 45-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, The Species, Morphs, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 45 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 40 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/axolotl/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free axolotl care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/axolotl/, and stays free.

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What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) with centimeters (cm) beside them. Tanks are measured in US gallons (gal), with liters (L) where a number matters. Water test readings are in parts per million (ppm): how many parts of a substance sit in a million parts of water. Small amounts are in milliliters (mL) and grams (g), and a salt bath's strength is in grams per liter (g/L). Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Check the law first, on page 22: an axolotl is legal without a permit in most of the United States, but it is banned, permit-only, conditional or unclear in fourteen places. Then read pages 4 to 12 in order before buying anything. Cooling is the decision that shapes the whole budget, and a new tank needs weeks of cycling before an axolotl goes in it. The Budget & Shopping List on page 32 lets you buy once.

If your axolotl is already home

Read the thermometer and test the water before you change anything else. Most axolotl problems that look like disease turn out to be a temperature or a water reading, and you cannot rule either out by looking at the animal. If anything seems off, go to the Red Flags page (page 24). If the water is already too warm, the steps that work in the next hour are on page 25.

Print these first

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| ☐ Page 30: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 37: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 31: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 38: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 34: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 39: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 35: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 40: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Axolotl advice contradicts itself most on the two things that matter most: how cold the water has to be, and what is safe to put on the tank floor. This package gives numbers you can test against, cross-checked against the veterinary and research sources listed on page 43.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An amphibian or aquatic veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book. Vets who see axolotls are rarer than small-animal vets, so find one before you need one and write the number on the emergency card. Nothing on the law pages is legal advice either.

SECTION 01 • PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Ambystoma mexicanum</i> , a mole salamander and a close relative of the tiger salamander
Adult size	9 to 12 in (23 to 30 cm)
Captive lifespan	10 to 15 years with consistent care; 5 to 6 years in the wild
Native range	The lake and canal system of Xochimilco, on the southern edge of Mexico City
Water temperature	60 to 64°F (15.6 to 17.8°C). Chronic stress above 72°F (22°C), and possibly fatal from about 75°F (24°C). Never a heater
Tank minimum	A 20 gal long tank for one adult; a 40 gal breeder if you keep two
Water targets	Ammonia 0 ppm, nitrite 0 ppm, nitrate under 10 ppm, pH 7.4 to 7.6, in a fully cycled tank (page 9)
Diet type	Carnivore: earthworms or nightcrawlers as the staple, with a sinking pellet made for axolotls
Feeding	Juveniles about daily, adults every 2 to 3 days (page 13)
Sexual maturity	Males at about 10 months, females at 12 to 18 months
Handling	Only when necessary, and with a container rather than hands. A pet to watch, not to hold
Conservation status	Critically Endangered on the Red List kept by the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature). Pet axolotls are captive-bred

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$30 to \$100 for a standard axolotl. \$120 to \$375 for the tank and equipment, or \$270 to \$775 with a chiller. Every line is on page 32.

Monthly ongoing

\$15 to \$45 for food, water conditioner, filter media and the electricity a chiller draws.

BUDGET FOR THE BAD MONTH TOO

An exam for an aquatic animal can cost more than one for a reptile or a bird, and tests, medication or surgery for a swallowed stone come on top. Keep a few hundred dollars set aside from the first week.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Axolotls regrow whole limbs, the tail, and parts of the eye, brain, spinal cord and heart, and the wound closes without a scar.
- They breathe four ways at once: through the skin, the lining of the mouth, the feathery gills, and simple lungs filled by gulping air at the surface.
- They have no eyelids, which is why dim, indirect light suits them.

The species, morphs, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

A salamander that keeps its larval body

The axolotl is a salamander from the lake and canal system of Xochimilco, in Mexico City, that keeps its larval body for life: feathery external gills, a finned tail and a fully aquatic habit. The word for this is paedomorphosis, and it is not the same as staying a baby. An axolotl reaches full adult size and breeds normally. Nor is it strictly permanent: the tissues still respond to thyroid hormone, and a high enough dose in a laboratory can push one through metamorphosis into a land-dwelling adult. What is underactive is the hormone system that would trigger it. In a home tank that never happens, which is why a correct setup has no land area and no basking spot.

Wild and captive

In the wild the species is close to gone. Surveys of the Xochimilco canals counted about 6,000 axolotls per square kilometer in 1998 and 36 in 2014, a fall of 99 percent, driven by pollution and by introduced carp and tilapia that eat eggs and young. In laboratories and home tanks it is common: most laboratory axolotls descend from six of the 34 animals shipped from Mexico City to Paris in 1864.

Morphs, in plain terms

A morph is a color variety. Every morph needs exactly the same cold water, food and care.

MORPH	WHAT IT IS
Wild type	Dark olive and speckled, the color of every wild axolotl.
Leucistic	Mostly white with dark eyes: fewer pigment cells develop, and most fail to reach the skin. The pale pet-shop axolotl.
Albino	No black pigment at all, because the enzyme that makes it is broken. The gene came from a tiger salamander crossed into the laboratory colony.
Melanoid	Solid dark, with many black pigment cells and none of the reflective ones. Sometimes sold as melanistic.
GFP (green fluorescent protein)	Carries a jellyfish gene for a glowing protein, first put into axolotls in 2006 for research. Glows green under ultraviolet light, and can be combined with any color.
Mosaic and chimera	Built from two genetically different cell lines, so one body carries patches of two morphs. A mosaic does not breed more mosaics, which is the whole price premium.

The common colors come from single genes, mostly recessive, so two wild-type parents can both carry a hidden color. A dark morph hides early redness and fungus, so look closer under good light.

Size and lifespan

Most adults finish at 9 to 12 in (23 to 30 cm). An axolotl commonly lives 10 to 15 years in captivity and 5 to 6 in the wild. Plan for house moves, summers away and a decade or more of hot Augusts.